

Sensory Doneness Cues

OptiMeal - Empyria - writing worksheet for Harris - v0.1

This is the one document Claude cannot write for you. A model can invent plausible-sounding cues, and plausible-sounding is precisely the failure. The examples below are models of the format, drawn from things you have already said. The vocabulary itself has to come from four years of watching people at a stove.

Why this exists

Right now a Cook Mode step is a duration plus some free text. The timer is the authority and any sensory language is decoration the model may or may not include. Your teaching inverts that: the cue is the authority and the timer is only an estimate of when to start checking. You cannot tell someone their potatoes are done in ten minutes - the pan, the oil, the hob, the material and the load all change it. What you can tell them is what done looks and feels like.

So every generated step will carry a required doneness check, and the cue must be chosen from a closed list. That list is what you are writing here. This is the third instance of the pattern that has already worked twice - cut vocabulary, then curriculum drawer key.

The structure of one entry

Field	What goes in it
cue_key	snake_case, stable, never shown to the user
sense	sight, touch, sound, smell, or taste
observable	What is actually true when it is ready. Neutral, factual.
what you say	The line in Chef Harris's voice. A question, not a statement.
if not ready	more_time, more_heat, less_heat, or stir_and_wait
applies to	Which density classes or proteins this cue is valid for

The **what you say** field is the one that matters most and the one only you can write. It is the difference between an app that reads out a recipe and an app that stands next to someone.

Worked examples

Twelve examples in the right format. Some are close to your own words from our conversation. Correct any that do not sound like you - they are a format demonstration, not a proposal.

cue_key	Sense	Observable	What you say	If not ready
fork_slides_easily	touch	A fork pushed into the thickest piece goes in and comes out with almost no resistance.	Push a fork into the biggest piece. Does it slide in and out easily?	more_time
fork_meets_resistance	touch	A fork goes in firmly but has to be pulled back out. Still has bite.	Pinch a piece with your fork. It should go in firmly and come back out reluctantly. That is crunchy, and that is what we want here.	more_time
edges_browned	sight	Golden to deep brown colour on the faces touching the pan, not just warmed through.	Lift one piece and look underneath. Is that a real golden edge, or is it still pale?	more_time
released_from_pan	touch	The piece lets go of the pan when nudged, instead of sticking.	Give it a nudge. If it sticks, it is not ready to turn. It will let go when it is.	more_time
translucent_no_color	sight	Softened and glassy at the edges with no browning at all.	Are your onions gone glassy and soft, with no colour on them yet?	less_heat
aroma_sweetened	smell	The raw sharp note is gone and the smell has turned sweet.	Lean over the pan. Do your onions smell sweeter than when they went in?	more_time
sizzle_steady	sound	A steady even sizzle, neither silent nor violent.	Listen to the pan. A steady sizzle means the heat is right. Silence means too low, spitting means too high.	more_heat
surface_dry	sight	No visible moisture pooling; the surface looks dry before it goes in the pan.	Is the surface dry to the eye? Wet food steams instead of browning.	more_time
reduced_by_half	sight	The liquid line sits at roughly half where it started.	Has the liquid dropped to about half? Look at the line it left on the pan.	more_time
coats_the_spoon	sight	A spoon drawn through leaves a line that holds for a moment before closing.	Draw your finger across the back of the spoon. Does the line hold, or does it run straight back?	more_time
flakes_apart	touch	Gentle pressure separates it along its natural lines.	Press gently with a fork. Does it start to come apart in flakes?	more_time
juices_run_clear	sight	Cut into the thickest part: flesh opaque and white throughout, juices clear, no pink flesh and no pink or red juice.	Cut into the thickest part. White all the way through and clear juices? Any pink at all and it goes back on.	more_time

Your entries

Aim for sixteen to twenty in total, the same scale as the cut vocabulary. Write more than you think you need - trimming later is easy, and the ones you write standing at a stove will be better than the ones you write at a desk.

cue_key	Sense	Observable	What you say	If not ready
aroma sweet and	smell	Less liquid in the pot/pan	If wine/alcohol doesn't smell acidic, sharp, alcoholic then it's done	more-time
sides browned	sight	turning brown on the sides (cookies)	if browned on the sides don't wait until fully brown or they will be dry	more-time
cold pan stainless steel	sight	drop is dancing and not evaporating	if the water floats/dances then it's ready.	more-time
steady bubbling	sight	oil heating. Wooden spoon or test bubbles or not	if bubbles ready to cook. if nothing, give it some time	more-time
hard bubbles on water	hear sound sight	rapid bubbles on surface of water perfect for Pasta	Wait for bubbles before adding pasta/bleaching. Temperature drops so, make sure it's rapidly boiling	more-time or not overcrowding
things with two sides (patties/flattened)	sight	check side before flipping, level your cut and check char/color	If colour is nice how you like it (I like it deep brown) then flip it	more-time flipping more turns more oily/dry
Green color on cutting board	sight	Soft greens wilted herbs / leafy	Don't overchop (rock & chop) on soft herbs. Lose chlorophyll waters and flavour	

Some things can be overcooked and taste great. Some cannot be undercooked. Aubergines/tomatoes/bean peppers are some examples. Potatoes/beetroot are these.

Never let a garlic turn dark brown. It will turn the whole food bitter. Better remove it and start over.

Instead of looking the time, use your senses. Do you see nice color, ingredients wilted, soft to the touch. Try the things you can safely try and cut through the things you cannot safely try.

- What do you say when someone asks you "is it done?" - the actual sentence.
- Which cue is different for the same ingredient at different textures - crunchy versus soft?
- What can you hear that tells you the heat is wrong before anything looks wrong?
- What smell change marks a real turning point in a pan?
- Where does a timer actively mislead someone, and what should they look at instead?

Written by	Date	Entries completed
chef Harris	17.08.2026	

